

100 Days of Linux - Day 034

Title: Extracting Columns with cut

Today's Goal

Learn how to extract specific columns and fields from text and CSV files using the **cut** command.

Why This Matters

Data engineers frequently work with CSV files and need to extract only the required columns without opening the file in a spreadsheet.

Command of the Day: cut

Syntax: cut [options] filename

Common Options:

cut -d ',' -f1 employees.csv (extract first column)

cut -d ',' -f2,3 employees.csv (extract multiple columns)

cut -c1-5 notes.txt (extract characters 1–5)

Explanation:

-d specifies the delimiter.

-f selects fields (columns).

-c selects character positions.

Beginner Lesson

Imagine a CSV file with columns like ID, Name, Department, and Salary. Instead of reading the entire file, the **cut** command lets you display only the columns you need.

Practice Questions

1. Create employees.csv with the columns ID, Name, Department, and Salary. Display only the Name column.
2. Display the Name and Department columns together from employees.csv.
3. Create products.csv with four columns. Display only the first and fourth columns.
4. Create notes.txt with one line of text. Display only the first 10 characters using cut.
5. Display your current working directory after completing today's tasks.

Hints

CSV files usually use commas, so remember to use -d ',' before selecting fields with -f.

Mini Challenge

Create sales.csv with five columns and at least five records. Extract only Product, Quantity, and Price columns. Then count the lines using wc -l.

Common Mistakes

Using the wrong delimiter. If your file is comma-separated, use -d ','. If it's colon-separated, use -d ':'.

Did You Know?

The cut command is often used in shell scripts to extract usernames, IDs, log fields, and CSV columns.

Pro Tip

Combine cut with grep, sort, and wc to build powerful text-processing workflows.

Answer Key (Instructor Only)

Q1: cut -d ',' -f2 employees.csv

Q2: cut -d ',' -f2,3 employees.csv

Q3: cut -d ',' -f1,4 products.csv

Q4: cut -c1-10 notes.txt

Q5: pwd

Homework

Create three CSV files with different columns and practice extracting individual and multiple fields using cut.

Next Day Preview

Tomorrow you'll learn the paste command to combine multiple files side by side.